

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

A shot rang out in the early hours of May 8 at a Border Security Force (BSF) camp in Barmer on the Rajasthan border. When the sleepy BSF post personnel awoke, they found constable Vishal Singh lying dead with a gaping wound in his chest. He had turned his 5.56 mm rifle towards himself and pressed the trigger, becoming the 10th BSF trooper to commit suicide this year. Preliminary inquiries revealed that the 27-year-old had shot himself hours after speaking with his wife. Just two days earlier, Trilok Singh, a BSF constable based in Gurdaspur, had received an emotional phone call from his wife complaining that his brother had made advances towards her. Trilok shot himself a few hours later.

In the past few years, the central police forces (CPFs)—comprising the BSF, Central Industrial Security Force (CISF), Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), National Security Guard (NSG), Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), Assam Rifles and Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB)—have been reversing rifles at themselves at an alarming rate. Last year, 113 men of the seven-lakh-strong CPFs committed suicide. A good percentage of these has occurred in the two largest paramilitaries, the BSF and the CRPF. The two-lakh-strong BSF, for instance, reported 44 suicides last year—a rate double that of the national civilian average of 12 suicides per one lakh people. Thirty men from the 2.67 lakh-strong CRPF committed suicide last year while 10 killed themselves in the last six months alone. Last year, the force reported 10 fratricides—the highest in its history—while two cases have been reported this year.

“Suicides are a major cause for concern. Unfortunately, all our present recruitment policy is too physically oriented, we have no psychological tests to see whether a recruit can take prolonged separation from his family, which our service entails,” says Ashish Kumar Mitra, director-general, BSF.

The army has a fairly low suicide rate of nine per one lakh. It took the 13-

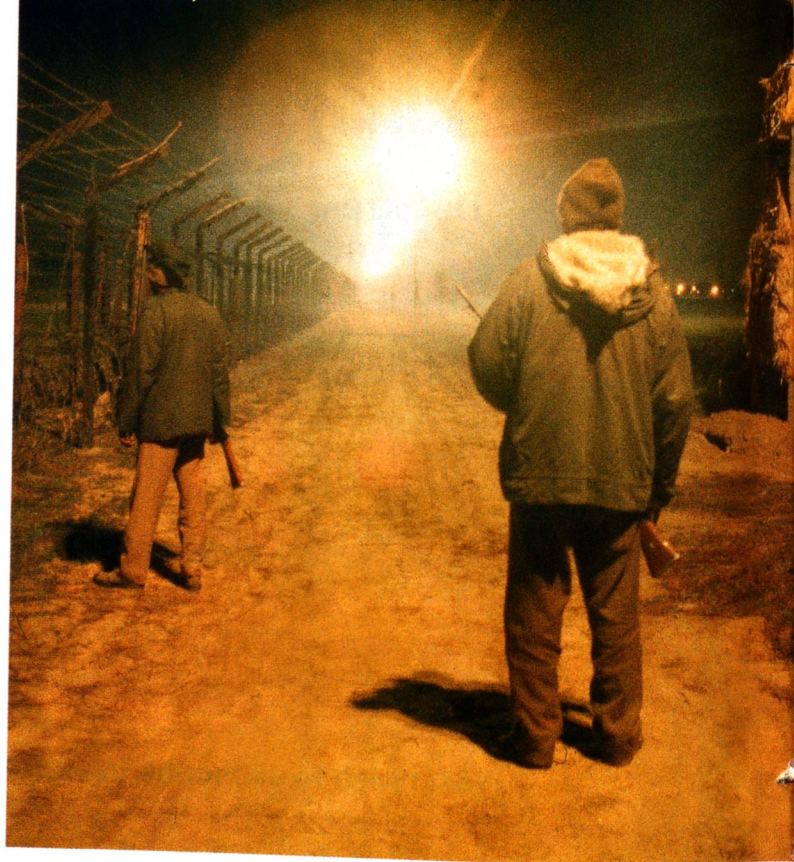
lakh-strong Indian Army two years and over 100 soldier deaths a year to realise it was losing more soldiers to suicides than to militancy. It is now studying the findings of the recently submitted report by the Defence Institute of Psychological Research. However, there have been no such comprehensive studies on suicides within the paramilitaries and hence no under-

standing of the problem. A few key trends emerge from an internal study recently conducted by the BSF.

In over 70 per cent of the cases, the jawan had killed himself after a conversation with his family, either through a PCO or a cellular phone, indicating that domestic discord induced stress. “Cheaper call costs mean that family members are more accessible, but also

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Stretched thin with internal security and border-guarding duties, the paramilitary forces are cracking up. They report suicide rates far higher than the armed forces, but the Government isn't alarmed.



“We have no tests to see if recruits can live away from their family.”

ASHISH KUMAR MITRA, DIRECTOR-GENERAL, BSF